

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 1492

By Vital

A RESOLUTION to honor the memory of Melvin Duley Cooper, Jr., of Chattanooga.

WHEREAS, the members of this General Assembly were greatly saddened to learn of the passing of Melvin Duley Cooper, Jr., of Chattanooga; and

WHEREAS, Mel Cooper was an exemplary public servant and consummate professional who worked assiduously to improve the quality of life for his fellow citizens in numerous capacities; and

WHEREAS, born on August 12, 1940, in Memphis, Melvin Duley Cooper, Jr., was the eldest child of Melvin Duley Cooper, Sr., and Sidney Mae Wilson, and he grew up helping his father in the family restaurant, the Electric Waffle Shop, that his grandmother started during the Great Depression; and

WHEREAS, Mel Cooper graduated from Central High School in Memphis in 1958 and Columbia University in New York in 1962; he returned to Memphis and taught in Shelby County public schools before changing his career path after the premature deaths of both of his parents; and

WHEREAS, under the mentorship of Bob Sharpe, an advocate of school development work through Robert F. Sharpe and Company, Mel Cooper became the first development officer for Memphis University School; and

WHEREAS, a trailblazer in the field of school fundraising, Mr. Cooper found a place in the National Association of Independent Schools and the Council for Advancement and Support of Education (CASE) and soon became a speaker, planner, and leader of workshops and conferences; and

WHEREAS, in 1974, Mel Cooper relocated to Chattanooga to become the first development officer for the McCallie School, where he built the school's development program

from the ground up, retiring in 2007 after thirty-four years of managing ongoing-strategic plans and cultivating major gifts with the board of trustees, leaving a substantial endowment and a large staff of professionals; and

WHEREAS, a highly respected leader in his community, Mr. Cooper was known for lending his time and talents to a number of schools and nonprofit organizations, including St. Andrews-Sewanee School, Bright School, the Mental Health Association, Chattanooga Opera Theater, Episcopal Commission of Southeast Tennessee, WTCI public television, A.I.M. Center, Chattanooga Symphony and Opera, and Grace Episcopal Church; and

WHEREAS, after his retirement, he served on the Friends of Moccasin Bend, which became National Park Partners; the Ed Johnson Committee, which established a memorial on the Walnut Street Bridge; and the Houston Museum for Decorative Arts, which will open a fully restored museum later this year; and

WHEREAS, among Mr. Cooper's many successful campaigns, the Sports and Athletic Center and the Alumni Dining Hall stand as glowing examples of his transformative achievements as a result of his dedication and drive; and

WHEREAS, no stranger to honors and accolades, Mel Cooper received the Robert Bell Crow Memorial Award, the highest national award in independent school professional advancement, from CASE in 2000 and the Burrows Award in 2002 for his service to St. Nicholas School in Chattanooga; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Cooper was also deeply devoted to his family, and he always endeavored to remain true to family values of the highest order; and

WHEREAS, Mel Cooper enjoyed the loving companionship of his wife of forty-four years, Eleanor McCallie Cooper, and was the proud father of Mae Cooper and Katie Cooper and the devoted grandfather of Alp and Leotie; and

WHEREAS, Melvin Duley Cooper, Jr., leaves behind an indelible legacy of integrity and probity in public life, compassion and loyalty in private life, and diligence and dedication in all his chosen endeavors; and

WHEREAS, it is fitting that the members of this General Assembly should pause to remember the bountiful life of this exceptional public servant and human being; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor the memory of Melvin Duley Cooper, Jr., reflecting fondly upon his impeccable character and his stalwart commitment to living the examined life with courage and conviction.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that we express our sympathy and offer our condolences to the family of Mr. Cooper.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.